EXCEL

Only 1 in 10 Data Analysts Get This Excel Question Right

The question: find the latest price of each product from a price history table. Most people return the first price, not the latest. Here is why, and 3 correct answers.

INSIDE THIS PDF · 7 PAGES

- The question
- The answer most people give
- Answer 1: XLOOKUP from the bottom
- Answer 2: by the latest date
- Answer 3: older Excel versions
- How to answer in the interview

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The question

Try it before you turn the page. This is how it is asked in interviews.

```
Sheet "History" (sorted by date, oldest first)

   A           B           C
1  Date        Product     Price
2  01-Jan-26   Pen         10
3  01-Jan-26   Notebook    40
4  15-Feb-26   Pen         12
5  10-Mar-26   Notebook    45
6  20-Apr-26   Pen         15

Sheet "Summary"
   A           B
1  Product     Latest price
2  Pen         ?      <- correct answer: 15
3  Notebook    ?      <- correct answer: 45
```

The task

Write one formula in B2 that returns the most recent price for the product in A2, and copy it down.

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The answer most people give

This is what 9 out of 10 candidates write. It looks right. It is wrong.

```
=VLOOKUP(A2, History!B:C, 2, FALSE)

Result for Pen:      10   (should be 15)
Result for Notebook: 40   (should be 45)
```

Why it is wrong

VLOOKUP, XLOOKUP and MATCH with exact match all stop at the FIRST match from the top. In a history table, the first match is the oldest row.

Why people miss it

The formula returns a valid price with no error. Nothing looks broken, so nobody checks.

This is what the question really tests: do you check whether a correct-looking number is actually the right one?

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Answer 1: XLOOKUP from the bottom

The cleanest answer in Excel 365 and Excel 2021+.

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, History!B:B, History!C:C, "Not found", 0, -1)
```

The key part

The last argument, -1, tells XLOOKUP to search from the last row upwards. The first match it finds is the latest.

Argument 5 = 0

Exact match.

Condition

The history must be sorted oldest to newest. If not, use Answer 2.

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Answer 2: by the latest date

Works even when the table is not sorted. This is the answer that impresses most.

```
Step 1: latest date for the product
=MAXIFS(History!A:A, History!B:B, A2)

Step 2: one formula with LET (Excel 365)
=LET(
   d, MAXIFS(History!A:A, History!B:B, A2),
   XLOOKUP(1,
     (History!B:B = A2) * (History!A:A = d),
     History!C:C))
```

How it works

MAXIFS finds the latest date for the product. The multiplication creates 1 only where both product and date match.

Best on a Table

Use structured references like History[Date] instead of full columns. Faster and easier to read.

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Answer 3: older Excel versions

If the company uses Excel 2016 or 2019, XLOOKUP and MAXIFS may not exist.

```
=LOOKUP(2, 1/(History!B$2:B$1000 = A2),
History!C$2:C$1000)
```

How it works

1/(condition) gives 1 for matching rows and #DIV/0! for others. LOOKUP searching for 2 cannot find it, so it returns the last 1, which is the last matching row.

Condition

Like Answer 1, it returns the last row in the table, so the data must be sorted by date.

Use a fixed range

Avoid full columns here. They slow this formula down a lot.

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How to answer in the interview

Say it in this order. It shows you understand the trap, not just the formula.

1. Name the trap

"A normal lookup returns the first match, which is the oldest price."

2. Ask about the data

"Is the history sorted by date? Can a product have two rows on the same date?"

3. Give the answer

"If sorted, XLOOKUP with search mode -1. If not, MAXIFS for the latest date and then match on product and date."

4. Verify

"I would check one product by filtering the history table to confirm."

Comment your answer. If you wrote VLOOKUP before reading this, you are in the 9 out of 10. Now you are not.

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